MAKE IT DO

Bread, eggs, milk, gas, a stamp and an hour's pay, as the government's own price agents wrote them down in 1953, beside real color film of the time. With the names in the hospital nursery that year, a recipe from the government's kitchen, and two pages for what it cost in your own house.

From the film *Everyday Life in 1950s America, in Real Color Film*. Frames from *A Word to the Wives* (c. 1955) and *Shopping Can Be Fun* (1957), public domain.

1953

Your Year, *in Color*



For Margaret, born 1953

What things cost the year you were born, from the government's own records

THE KITCHEN

What the groceries cost in 1953

IN 1953	THE RECORD	TODAY
A pound of white bread per pound	16¢	**$1.87** per pound
A dozen eggs per dozen	70¢	**$4.25** per dozen
Half a gallon of milk delivered to the door	47¢	**$2.03** half a gallon, at the store
A pound of butter per pound	79¢	**$4.76** per pound
A pound of coffee per pound	89¢	**$8.18** per pound
Five pounds of sugar 5-pound bag	53¢	**$5.12** 5 pounds
Ten pounds of potatoes 10-pound bag	54¢	**$9.63** 10 pounds

THE NURSERY

The names on the cribs in 1953

Every baby born in 1953 with a Social Security number, counted. If you're one of these, here is how many of you there were.

Girls

1. Mary 64,389
2. Linda 61,281
3. Deborah 52,199
4. Patricia 51,019
5. Susan 44,297
6. Barbara 38,473
7. Debra 36,856
8. Nancy 30,620
9. Karen 29,858
10. Pamela 25,760

Boys

1. Robert 86,243
2. James 86,066
3. Michael 84,198
4. John 80,165
5. David 76,119
6. William 61,829
7. Richard 58,389
8. Thomas 47,008
9. Charles 38,421
10. Gary 36,967

Social Security Administration, Popular Baby Names, national data, 1953. Counts are babies later issued a Social Security card, so early years count fewer.

FOR THE FAMILY

Questions to ask

If this book was a present, here is what to ask the person it's for. Write the answers in.

What did your mother make on a weeknight when money was short?

What did a week of groceries cost your family, and who paid?

What did the first car you remember look like, and what color was it?

Where did the family go on a Saturday?

What did you get paid for your first job?

Which of the prices in this book surprises you most?